

The social problem I thought of is that there's an immobility in job market on specialized jobs. As an economy gets more complex, creates high-value and jobs get more specialized, these jobs cluster in specific firms and cities. This creates a 'gate', locking out qualified individuals from different socioeconomic backgrounds who lack the weak ties into that cluster. The problem is important and relevant because it limits people with poorer socioeconomic backgrounds and also limits the chance for these specialized markets to improve by letting diverse individuals taking part in it.

The problem causes that information about the specialized jobs, and referrals required to get them, circulates within the same cluster. (3) The clustering of jobs in specific firms and cities, combined with the small-world nature of social networks, creates barriers for low-socioeconomic status individuals to access high-socioeconomic status opportunities. The small-world nature of social networks, characterized by high clustering, can lead to fragmentation and limit the flow of information across groups. (Considering homophily in these clusters based on previous studies. (2)) There are findings about the critical role of economic connectedness in breaking these barriers and improving access to upward mobility. In the problem weak ties can help break down the barriers created by homophily, allowing individuals from different classes and educational backgrounds to connect with those in high-value job clusters. (1)

A niche that needs better understanding in my opinion is the costs of these bridges. Accessing and navigating a high-income social cluster, for example to get the referral (3), often requires significant changes, like cultural assimilation, and time investment, which may be a hidden barrier that explains why these bridges don't form. The question is: What are the unmeasured social, psychological, and cultural costs for individuals from low-socioeconomic backgrounds to establish and maintain the weak ties that are essential for mobility?

A stakeholders could be high-complexity firms in tech or finance that employ individuals with specialized knowledge and this clustering occurs at. They could be reached by new possible employees who brought a new view to the given field by not coming from the same cluster. This could create an opportunity for firms to get a diverse view on certain problems leading to more efficient solutions. Other stakeholders could be policymakers because if the 'gated market' is real, it means the economy is inefficient, which leads to lower GDP and innovation than potential. The question on costs helps them design policies that help people cross the bridge.

(1) Granovetter, M. S. (1973). The strength of weak ties. *American Journal of Sociology*, 78(6), 1360-1380.

(2) Chetty, R., Jackson, M. O., et al. (2022). Social capital I: measurement and associations with economic mobility. *Nature*, 608, 108-119.

(3) Fernandez, R. M., Castilla, E. J., & Moore, P. (2000). Social Capital at Work: Networks and Employment at a Phone Center. *American Journal of Sociology*, 105(5), 1288-1356.